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The web of kinship among the Tallensi

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The Nuclear Relationship of Mother's Brother and Sister's Son

A child makes the acquaintance of its mother's paternal family very early in life. Its mother's sisters and mother's mother, if she is not too old, are frequent visitors to its mother. Its mother's brothers may be frequent visitors too, especially if they are on friendly terms with its father. But it is not till the child reaches the age of about 5 or 6, when it begins to be taken on visits to its *ah(ə)b yiri*, that it clearly distinguishes these relatives. The person who matters most to a small child at its mother's brother's house is its maternal grandmother (*ma-kpeem*), in whose quarters and under whose care the child lives.¹ Old people, both men and women, love to have their daughters' young children to stay with them, and pet and spoil them quite as much as their sons' children. As will be remembered, grandchildren joke with their maternal grandparents. At harvest time, in particular, old women often have daughters' children to stay for a week or two, so that they can enjoy the good food available at that time. Playing and eating and sleeping with the children of the house, a child learns to regard them as siblings, and partly through imitating them, partly through coming directly under the discipline of his mother's brother, a child thus visiting its *ah(ə)b yiri* learns to think of its *ah(ə)b* as a 'sort of father'. He hears all the gossip of the family. When a domestic sacrifice is performed he is present and receives the portion of the animal—the neck (*nanjoor*)—prescribed for an *ah(ə)ŋ*. I have more than once seen a small boy of perhaps 8 receive the neck of a sacrifice, amid an amused chuckle from his mother's brothers. If a woman dies leaving a young child of less than 5 or 6 years old it is a common thing for the child to be sent to live with its maternal grandmother for a year or two until it is old enough to need only a minimum of maternal care.

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Thus, a child learns to think of its *ah(ə)b yiri*, in the strict sense of its mother's brother's homestead, at first, in the more extended sense, later, as a place where it is given food, shelter, affectionate attention, and  302 status in almost the same way as in its own home. It is not surprising to find that most Tallensi know almost as much about the affairs of their mother's brother's family as they do about their own family, and that they often have a very good knowledge of the distinctive ritual practices and ideas of their mother's brother's clan. For though a sister's child is not admitted to the esoteric ritual ceremonies of his maternal kinsmen's clan, he often hears them discuss the less sacred aspects of these ceremonies and takes part in the domestic rites that are interspersed with them.

¹ This follows directly from the constitution of the joint family.

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